

Statistics

With 7 dxc5 White has scored 61% from 419 games and with 9 exd5, 52%. White has also done well with the rare 8 dxe6, scoring 63%. I think there are a whole load of King's Indian players out there who haven't got a clue what to do against these moves.

Illustrative Games

Game 50

□ Conquest ■ Mestel

Hastings 1986/87

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 d6 3 Nc3 g6 4 e4 Bg7 5 f4 0-0 6 Nf3 c5 7 d5 e6 8 Be2 exd5 9 exd5

This is a more cautious and less popular approach than 9 cxd5. White keeps the pawn structure balanced and hopes that his extra space will be enough for an edge. However, his position would be much healthier if his pawn were back on f2. On f4 it blocks in the bishop on c1 and weakens squares on the e-file. Black's main goal should be to stop White from advancing f4-f5.

9...Bf5

The most logical move, immediately taking control of e4. A more radical idea is 9...Nh5!? 10 0-0 Bxc3 11 bxc3 when Black must now blockade the f5-square. He can do this at once with 11...f5 or with 11...Ng7 intending ...Nf5. In the case of the latter White may sacrifice a pawn with 12 f5 to open the position but Black has done OK in practice.

10 0-0 Re8 11 Bd3

Black plans to meet 11 Nh4 with 11...Ne4!, not fearing the shattering of his kingside pawn structure. In return he will increase his grip in the centre, e.g. 12 Nxf5 gxf5 13 Nxe4 fxe4 is fine for Black.

11...Qd7!

Better than 11...Ne4 12 Nxe4 Bxe4 13 Bxe4 Rxe4 14 Ng5! as White can obtain good attacking chances by playing f4-f5 next move.

12 h3

White plans to lift Black's blockade by playing g4 – risky, as we shall see. Again 12 Nh4 would have been met by 12...Ne4!.

12...Na6 13 a3

A standard reaction to prevent ...Nb4.

13...Nc7 14 g4

White had prepared this advance with his 12th move. It doesn't mean that it's good. 14 Qc2 is well met by 14...b5!. Black will be more than happy if he can exchange his b-pawn for the d-pawn as this will give him more control in the centre and liberate his knight on c7.

14...Bxg4!? (Diagram 11)

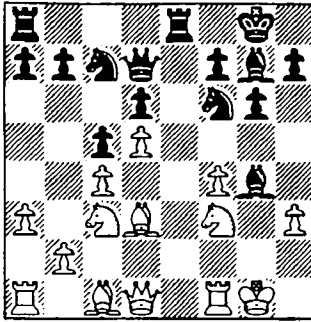


Diagram 11

This sacrifice guarantees a draw

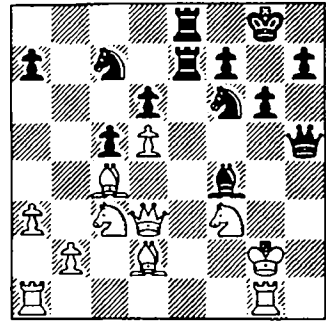


Diagram 12

A second bishop sacrifice!

An interesting, though not necessarily courageous decision. The point is that it is very easy for a grandmaster to calculate that the sacrifice guarantees at least a draw. 14...Bxd3 15 Qxd3 b5! 16 cxb5 Reb8 17 a4 a6 is a reasonable alternative with good Benko-style compensation for the pawn.



TIP: When playing a sacrifice you don't have to work out everything in advance. If you see a position a few moves ahead which looks fine then go for it. You can continue your calculations when you get there, but this time with full sight of the board.

15 hxc4 Qxc4+ 16 Kh2 Qh5+ 17 Kg2 Qg4+ 18 Kh2

White cannot avoid the draw as 18 Kh1 Qh3+ 19 Nh2 Nh5 lands him in trouble. The moment of decision has arrived for Black.

18...b5!?

Mestel plays for the win, but with a most surprising move on the queenside. We saw a similar idea in the notes to move 14 – Black wants to weaken White's protection of d5 as if this pawn drops then more Black pieces can come flooding into the attack.

19 Rg1 Qh5+ 20 Kg3?

Straightaway Black is rewarded for his bravery. Conquest chooses the wrong square for his king. He should have played 20 Kg2.

20...bxc4 21 Bxc4 Re7!

Black prepares to double rooks on the e-file.

22 Qd3 Bh6 23 Kg2

White was worried about 23 . Bxf4+ 24 Bxf4 Qg4+ so he makes this rather sad admission of his earlier mistake.

23...Rae8 24 Bd2 Bxf4!! (Diagram 12)

With the investment of a second piece the Black attack becomes irresistible.

25 Bxf4 Qg4+ 26 Bg3

This is why the white king had retreated from g3 – so he would have this defence. However, it is still not enough to save him.

26...Re3 27 Qf1 Nh5! 28 Kh2 Rxf3 29 Qh3 Qxc4 White resigns

Game 51

□ I.Sokolov ■ Xie Jun

Dutch Team Championship, 1999

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f4 0-0 6 Nf3 c5 7 dxc5 Qa5!

If it wasn't for this move then 6...c5 would not be the main line against the Four Pawns Attack. Few Black players are willing to defend the passive position that arises after 7...dxc5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 9 e5.

8 Bd3

8 cxd6 Nxe4 should be avoided at all costs by White

8...Qxc5 9 Qe2

White plans Be3 and 0-0. Much of the play will now revolve around the battle for the d4-square. Black will play moves such as ...Nc6, ...Bg4xf3 and ...Nf6-d7, all of which increase his control of d4, while White will try and defend it with Be3, Qf2 and a rook to the d-file.

9...Nc6 10 Be3 Qa5 11 0-0 Bg4 (Diagram 13) 12 Rc1

Advancing the queenside pawns too early can lead to trouble. Terzic-Cvitan, Bosnia 1999 continued 12 a3 Nd7 13 b4 Qh5 14 Qd2 Bxf3 15 Rxf3 Nd4 16 Rh3? Qxh3! 17 gxh3 Nf3+ and Black won the exchange and the game.

12...Nd7 13 Qf2 Nc5 14 Bb1 Bxf3 15 gxf3

Recapturing with the queen would allow Black to occupy the d4-square. Besides, White is happy to take with the pawn as he hopes to develop an attack along the semi-open g-file.

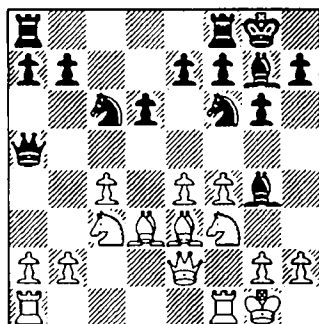


Diagram 13

The battle revolves around d4

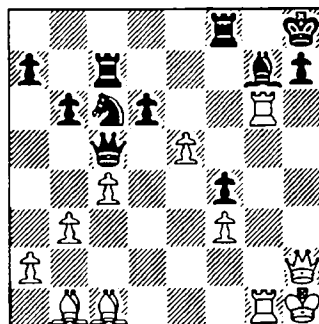


Diagram 14

The bishop on b1 joins the attack



15...Na4

NOTE: It is usually a good idea for Black to swap of the white knight on c3 in the King's Indian. This is true here, as without the knight Black will find it easier to develop an initiative on the queenside and will no longer have to concern himself with White playing an annoying Nd5.

16 Nxa4 Qxa4 17 Rfd1 b6?!

I don't like this move as it leaves the black queen cut off from the kingside theatre. A better plan for Black was demonstrated in Topalov-Dolmatov, Elenite 1995: 17...Rac8 18 b3 Qa5 19 Rd5 Qc7 20 Rcd1 b6 21 a3 Rfd8 22 h4 e6 23 Rg5 Qe7 24 h5 Qf6. Now there is no mating attack as the black queen helps in the defence. The game was eventually drawn in 75 moves.

18 Kh1 Rac8 19 h4! Rc7 20 h5 Nb4 21 hxg6 fxg6 22 b3 Qa5 23 Rg1! Kh8?!

Black had probably intended 23...Qh5+ here but after 24 Kg2 and 25 Rh1 the queen will have to go back to the queenside.

24 Rg5 Qa3 25 Qh2 e5

Black wanted to stop White playing e4-e5 as that would bring the long range bishop on b1 into the attack.

26 Rcg1 Nc6 27 Rxg6 exf4 28 Bc1 Qc5 29 e5! (Diagram 14)

Despite Black's efforts White gets to play this move anyway. There is nothing to be done for Black now.

29...Nxe5 30 Re6 Bf6 31 Qh6 Black resigns

The Modern 6...Na6

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f4 0-0 6 Nf3 Na6 (Diagram 15)

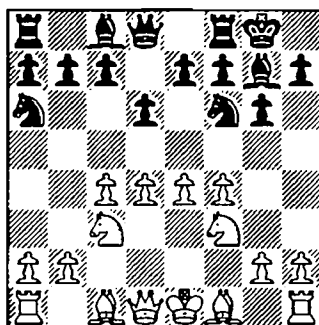


Diagram 15

6...Na6. A provocative move

At the start of the 1990's the move ...Na6 became extremely fashionable in many variations of the King's Indian. Nobody seriously assumed that Black could play it against the Four Pawns Attack, but he can! It even received the ultimate seal of approval when Garry Kasparov started playing it. Nowadays it is almost as popular as 6...c5.

What is the point of 6...Na6?

The basic idea is to enable Black to strike in the centre with ...e7-e5. He can't do this at once because after 6...e5 7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Nxe5 he is just a pawn down. If, though, he could play ...Nc5 in this position he would get serious counterplay against White's centre. This is the way Black plays against the most natural move 7 Be2 and that is examined in Game 52.

White players soon went off taking the pawn and started blocking the centre with d4-d5. At first they used to do this with the bishop on e2, but then realised that they may as well play 7 Bd3 if they are just going to block the centre. This move is covered in Game 53. 7 e5 is the most overtly aggressive move available to White (Game 54)

Theoretical?

Less than the main lines of 6...c5 but there are some concrete variations which have to be learnt.

Statistics

The statistics show that Black scores better with 6... Na6 than 6...c5. White only manages a slightly below par 52% from nearly 700 games.

Illustrative Games

Game 52

□ Ca.Hansen ■ Berg

Aarhus 1991

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 f4 0-0 6 Nf3 Na6 7 Be2 e5! 8 dxe5

It would be very risky for White to play 8 fxe5 dxe5 9 Nxe5, because of the riposte 9...c5!. Now 10 d5 allows 10...Nxe4 and after 10 Be3 cxd4 11 Bxd4 Qe7! with ...Rd8 to follow, White's position is very shaky.

If White plays 8 fxe5 dxe5 then it usually means that he is going to block the centre with 9 d5. This is a perfectly reasonable plan but through accurate play Black can hold the balance.

Exercise 8: After 9...Nc5 what happens if White defends the pawn with 10 Qc2? (Diagram 16)

After 9...Nc5 10 Bg5 h6 11 Bxf6 Qxf6 12 b4 Na6 13 a3 c5! the chances were about equal in Lautier-Kasparov, Amsterdam 1995. White has a